

Romance Mesocleft and the Final-over-Final Condition

April 13, 2025

1 Introduction

The paper looks at sequences with a linear order of *verbal root* - *pronomial object marker* - *verbal agreement marker* in the Romance languages. Such phenomena largely fall into two subtypes: in futures/conditionals (FC) (1a), and in imperatives (1b).

- (1) a. *dar-lhe-ei*
give-INF=3SG.DAT-FUT-1SG
'I will give (it) to him.' (European Portuguese)
- b. *véndalo-n*
sell=3SG.ACC-PL
'Sell-PL it.' (Dialectal Spanish, from Harris and Halle, 2005, pg. 195)

These phenomena are attested variously but unstably across diatopic and diachronic axes. They display significant variation in their properties and formal analyses, and do not form a uniform class. They have received abundant attention in the Romance linguistics literature, due to their importance for topics like lexical integrity, the nature of clitics/affixes, and grammaticalisation of synthetic verb forms. The most significant debates in the literature will be introduced here, but I do not offer novel contributions.

Instead, this paper looks at them from the perspective of the Final-over-Final Condition (FOFC) (Sheehan et al., 2017). The status and extent of this condition is subject to significant debate (see Biberauer and Rowe, *shd*, for a review), but at a vague level it is a restriction against linear permutations of certain syntactic heads in the below order:

- (2) $*[\alpha_P [\beta_P \beta [\gamma_P \gamma]] \alpha]$

This restriction is well motivated in certain domains (Biberauer et al., 2017). A strong point of argumentation comes from diachronic Germanic, where five of the six linear permutations of auxiliary verb (T), lexical verb (V), and object (O) have appeared as an unmarked order, with *VOT* the only exception.

- (3) *I give (it) to him will.

The mesocleft examples, particularly (1a), have a similar linear order on the surface to (3). Romance data has been used in investigating FOFC, because the diachronic development from head-final to head-initial order from Latin to Romance (Ledgeway, 2012) has been used as support for FOFC, as this proceeded top down.

However, mesocleft examples have not been considered relevant to FOFC¹. The reasons for this include debate about the place of generation of clitics, which might mean no FOFC-violating structure is ever produced, and the pragmatically marked nature of these constructions. This paper agrees that Romance mesocleft, in whatever form it takes, poses few issues for most explanations of FOFC, but looks at the proposed nature of these constructions, and why FOFC should not apply to these domains. I particularly look at the relation of FOFC to Information Structure (IS) and prosody, proposing that mesocleft data supports analysis of FOFC as epiphenomenal from third-factor constraints (Biberauer, 2018).

¹With the exception of (Medeiros, 2021, footnote 33).

2 Mesoclis Data

2.1 Futures/Conditionals

The synthetic future in Latin has not survived in any Romance languages. Across the history of Latin, it was also possible to form futures analytically in a number of ways. The most ancient of these was INF + *habeo*, eg. ‘cantare habeo’, where *habeo* is the auxiliary ‘to have’ Alvar and Pottier (1983, pg. 246-7). This head-final order is consistent with unmarked Latin SOV order. Analytic constructions with the reverse linear order also occurred later in the development of Latin. Grammaticalisation of this head-final auxiliary into a suffix has led to the Romance synthetic future, although the romance languages have switched to basic SVO order, which occurs for all synchronic periphrastic constructions.

- (4) *Ho mangiato.*
have-1SG eat-PP
‘I have eaten.’ (Italian)

The term *mesoclis* implies that there is the sequence *root - clitic - affix*. This term is used for European Portuguese (EP) and Old Occitan (Bach, 2024), but is controversial as definitions of clitic often rule out the possibility for them to occur word-internally (Haspelmath, 2023), and in Romance specifically, the status of agreement markers on the verb as either clitics or affixes is hotly debated (Zwicky, 1987; Halpern, 1995; Vigário, 1999).

The term *Analytic Future* (AF) is used in constructions where the auxiliary is clearly a separate word (5a), particularly in the literature on Old Spanish. AFs have been described as a ‘Panromanic phenomenon’ (Silva-Villar, 1995, pg. 239), as they are found in various languages of the medieval Iberian peninsula, Judeo-Spanish, and in Old Italian². In the *Synthetic Future* (SF)s, the auxiliary is attached to the lexical verb (5b).

- (5) a. *Dezir te hia.*
say-INF you-CL go-1SG.IMPF
‘I would tell you.’
b. *Te diria.*
you-CL say-1SG.COND
‘I would tell you.’
(Medieval Spanish (MS)), Oudin (1597, pg. 97), cited in Anipa (2000, pg. 329)

Of particular interest in (5) is the difference in stem between the AF and SF. For the majority of verbs, the FC stem is identical to the infinitive. For a small number of verbs, the FC stem differs (Bernal, 2004), and this is relevant to Old Occitan, where mesoclis is only available for verbs with identical infinitives and FC stems (Bach, 2024).

There has been significant debate about whether the AF and SF constructions are equivalent, with differing position of the clitic, or separate constructions in another way. This has been investigated by looking at the respective frequencies in medieval texts (Batllori Dillet, 2012; Company Company, 1985; Enrique-Arias and Bouzouita, 2013; Graham, 2018). These investigations have found differences in syntactic-pragmatic contexts between the two forms, and agree in treating them as non-equivalent.

In particular, the idea of AFs as constructions as pragmatically marked is recurrent. This relies on assuming an articulated left-periphery (Cinque, 1999). I will discuss in section (3) that an articulated left-periphery has not been seen as relevant to FOFC. Comparisons have been made to other Romance fronting structures like Participle Preposing found in MS (Batllori, 2011) and Old Romanian (Zafiu, 2014), the latter of which is analysed as auxiliary encliticisation:

- (6) *Dicho lo an*
say-PP it-CL have-3PL
‘They have told it.’
(Batllori, 2011)

Participle Preposing is suggested as an example of XP movement, and AF as long head movement (Lema and Rivero, 1989, 1991). Differences in these two types of movement include the notable difference of AFs never co-occurring with

²AFs have not been attested in French and certain Italian dialects, which poses the question of whether this is a true ‘panromanic phenomenon’ lost early in these languages, or separate innovations.

negation³. Similarly, mesoclis is compared to stylistic fronting by Pescarini (2021, pg. 220-225), a construction involving the fronting of bare constituents most well known in Germanic (Holmberg, 2000).

The impossibility negation has been linked to the evidential left-peripheral position of these constructions: ‘Furthermore, it turns to be crosslinguistically valid that grammaticalized evidentials cannot be within the scope of negation’ (Batllori, 2011, pg. 14). The exact markedness of AFs is traditionally assumed to be focalisation, but Batllori Dillet (2016); Batllori Dillet (2012) argues that these are speech act mood modals.

Another debate is whether the possibility of mesoclis or AFs disappeared due to complete grammaticalisation of SFs. This has traditionally been assumed, although Anipa (2000)’s analysis from contemporary MS grammarians shows no evidence that SFs should have evolved from AFs. There was a geographical element to the variation, as AF constructions became obsolete early in Occitan (Bach, 2024), Catalan (Sentí and Bouzouita, 2022), and Navarro-Aragonese (Primerano and Bouzouita, 2024) but persisted into the 17th century in Spanish (Anipa, 2000) and remains in EP. EP is especially relevant as the constructions have been argued to be ‘true’ mesoclis, as opposed to an AF⁴, in that the auxiliary has completed grammaticalisation to a suffix. Alternative analyses either treat both the pronominal element and the tense element as affixes (Zwicky, 1987; Halpern, 1995), or both as clitics (Vigário, 1999). The former approach is justified by that fact that pronominal elements must attach to verbs, not having the freedom of host selection that other clitics do, and by phonological idiosyncracies such as the differing forms of the stem *comes* and pronominal element *o* when combined in (7), a trait commonly argued for clitics.

- (7) *comes*; *como-o*; *come-lo*
eat-PRES.2SG eat-PRES.1SG-3SG.ACC eat-PRES.2SG-3SG.ACC
‘You eat’; ‘I eat it’; ‘You eat it’. (Vigário, 1999, (2a))

The latter approach is justified as pronominal elements can attach before or after verb stems, unlike other EP inflectional affixes which are uniformly suffixes, and that the tense element has a separate primary stress. The major point of contention between these approaches is whether mesoclis should be considered a lexical or post-lexical phenomenon, that is handled in the morphology of syntax respectively. The double affix approach is lexical in nature, and the double clitic one is post-lexical. By contrast, Crysmann (1997) argues that a combination of the two are required, in that syntactic constraints determine whether there is the environment for proclisis or enclisis (which mesoclis is a particular case of) and morphology can impact the idiosyncratic morphophonological rules.

Modern EP (and other West Iberian languages) can still display mesoclis as they allow finite enclisis, unlike other Romance languages. Proclisis is mandatory when preceded by a triggering element like sentential negation or matrix wh-element - these do not form a syntactic natural class, but a prosodic one in their belonging to an Intonational Phrase with the verb (Barbosa, 1996). Barbosa’s analysis is that there is a restriction against clitics aligned with the left-edge of an Intonational Phrase (8), a refinement of the *Tobler-Mussafia* law of Medieval romance, which would ban clause initial clitics.

- (8) *[_{IntP} cl X...] (Barbosa, 1996, (8))

When this would be violated, enclisis occurs, unless in FC contexts, where mesoclis occurs⁵. The position between the two verbal elements is explained as they have distinct primary stresses, as mentioned above, although some EP speakers accept enclisis in FC contexts (Vigário, 1999), so would have (9) instead of (1a).

- (9) *darei-lhe*
give-FUT-1SG=3SG.DAT
‘I will give (it) to him.’ (European Portuguese)

³The example

- (i) *Nu lăsa-se-va sufletul lui în Iad (CB.22)*
not let.INF-CL.ACC.3SG-AUX.3SG soul.DET his in Hades
‘His soul will not be abandoned to Hades.’

is quoted in Zafiu (2014, pg. 76), although they note it is translated from a Slavonic source, where this linear order is attested.

⁴This is also true for Old Occitan (Bach, 2024).

⁵In Old Occitan mesoclis only occurred with futures, suggesting the grammaticalisation paths could have differed (Bach, 2024).

2.2 Imperatives

Many of the same debates have occurred in examples of mesoclis in the imperative, of the type (1b). Such phenomena are found across the Spanish-speaking Caribbean, in Calabro-Lucanian and Lombardy dialects of Italy, and Tosk Albanian varieties (eg. Manzini and Savoia, 1999; Manzini and Savoia, 2011; Savoia and Baldi, 2023)⁶. The Spanish examples have plural *-n* as more peripheral than an object clitic, whereas examples from Italy and Albania can display peripheral person agreement in addition. Examples (10) show how the subject imperative agreement is more peripheral than one clitic, but less so than another, in a ditransitive construction.

- (10) a. *hua- mmə- ni ε*
say me.DAT 2pl it
‘Say (PL) it to me.’ (*S. Marzano, Arb eresh (Albanian)* Manzini and Savoia, 2011, (11b))
- b. *putæ- d’d- imə- lə.*
bring 3 1PL 3
‘Let us bring it/them to him/her/them!’ (*Senise, (Lucania, Romance)* Manzini and Savoia, 2011, (12))

The major point of interest for these studies is clusters of object clitics and their possible linear ordering with respect to one another and verbal agreement. The trends found are outside the scope of this paper. More relevant is patterns of double agreement, particularly with clitic clusters. Harris and Halle (2005) give the following possibilities for different dialects in addition to (1b).

- (11) a. vénda-n-lo (Standard)
b. vénda-lo-n (Mesoclis, (1b))
c. vénda-n-lo-n (Doubling)
d. véndan-me-lo (Standard)
e. vénda-me-n-lo
f. vénda-me-lo-n
g. vénda-me-n-lo-n
h. vénda-n-me-n-lo
i. vénda-n-me-lo-n
j. vénda-n-me-n-lo-n

Note that no speakers can use all of these, and there are implicational hierarchies between these. For example, some speakers allow (11e) and (11f), some allow (11e) but not (11f), but no speakers allow (11f) but not (11e). This bears a strong resemblance to monotonicity phenomena across languages, argued to derive from the same conditions as FOFC (Biberauer, 2018). One of the examples Biberauer presents, from Cardinaletti and Shlonsky (2004), is given below for comparison.

- (12) a. **Li** ho voluti fare andare a prendere a Maria.
them I.have want.PP make.INF go.INF to deliver.INF to Maria
‘I wanted to make Maria go and fetch them.’
- b. **Li** ho voluti far andare a prendere a Maria.
c. **Li** ho voluti far andar a prendere a Maria.
d. ***Li** ho voluti fare andar a prendere a Maria.

In (12), the point of interest is the infinitival *-e* marking, which can be dropped according to a sequential pattern, but this pattern cannot have any gaps in it as in (12d).

It is quickly worth noting that Romance imperatives are argued to move to a very high position (Rivero, 1994). Some examples of lower mesoclis phenomena in infinitives and indicatives are given by Kayne (2010) and Savoia and Baldi (2023)⁷.

⁶This has also been argued for some French liaison of the plural *-z* (Laenzlinger, 1998), which will not be pursued here.

⁷SCI is Subject Clitic, not relevant to this discussion.

- (13) a. *dá- r- se- lo* (*Standard Spanish*)
 give INF REFL it
 ‘to give it to him/her.’
- b. *dá- se- r- lo* (*Non-standard Spanish, Google Result*)
 give REFL INF it
 (Kayne, 2010, (82))
- c. *i tfam- m- u* (*Treccate, Piedmont (Romance)*)
 SCI call 1SG 3PL
 ‘They call me.’
 (Savoia and Baldi, 2023, (30))

These are not pursued here for absence of data, although it is noted for the analysis in (3) that these also display movement, and the lexical nature of reflexives may also be relevant.

There are differing analyses for the locus of mesoclitisis in imperatives: phonology (Harris and Halle, 2005), morphology (Halle and Marantz, 1994) or syntax (Kayne, 2010; Manzini and Savoia, 2011). The phonological approach uses a rule of metathesis, or partial reduplication, whereas the morphological approach has postsyntactic reordering of the morphemes which are structurally adjacent. For both of these, the motivation is to keep plural marking *-n* in final position linearly, as it otherwise is. Both of these operations are challenged as overly powerful (Kayne, 2010), and their existence would pose questions for word-order universals like FOFC. The syntactic approaches postulate that the verbal agreement morpheme reaches a high position and needs a verb stem to raise to it at some point in the derivation. The verb stem can however move further, and certain clitics may also move to precede the agreement morpheme, depending on hierarchical position.

3 Final-Over-Final Condition

The above discussion has shown there is considerable variety in structures displaying a surface FOFC violating linear order. The approach to such surface violations has been to treat them with ‘enlightened persistence’ (Pesetsky, 2017, pg. xii), investigating further to find deeper explanations. Many of the same debates recurring in the mesoclitisis literature also appear in the FOFC literature. These two domains have not seen significant interaction, and I do not disagree that these mesoclitisis examples are not at the core of the factors behind FOFC. However, I will look at what enlightened persistence here might indicate about the nature of FOFC, and when it does not apply.

3.1 Diachrony

The distribution of mesoclititic structures is interesting. There are a number of attestations across different periods of space and time, but they are relatively infrequent and unstable in the big picture of Romance variation. The attestations tend to be grouped together unevenly, heading westward across medieval Iberia, in modern New World Spanish, in late medieval Romanian-Slavic areas, and in Italian-Albanian varieties. It seems probable that contact is involved in the spread of these structures in some cases, even if the exact diachrony cannot be proved. The borrowing of surface FOFC-violating structures has also been observed in the postverbal aspect particle *already* in Singlish, under Chinese contact (Erlewine, 2023). The ability for contact situations, presumably involving L2 acquisition, to borrow FOFC-violating structures needs to be considered for theoretical explanations.

Another point to consider is how these marked structures arise in relatively specific circumstances - the switch from OV to VO and the shift from Latin style non-configurationality to stricter word order requirements (Ledgeway, 2012). The rareness of these other changes might help explain the rareness of mesoclititic constructions outside of romance. This fits in with the suggestion that cross-categorical word order universals, including FOFC, arise statistically from diachronic considerations (Whitman, 2008; Whitman and Ono, 2017). Some indirect support for this comes from Udmurt (Uralic), which has also changed from OV to VO, and largely matches the FOFC predictions for this diachronic change occurring top-down, but contains some surface FOFC violations (Asztalos, 2019).

3.2 Locus of FOFC

Another central concern in both works is the architecture of the grammar, or more narrowly how competing constraints from different areas such as phonology, morphology and syntax should interact. If morphology is held to be meaningfully distinct from syntax, FOFC might only hold in the latter. This is the view of Philip (2012), citing examples such as the following.

(14) [v[v be_N head]]ed] (Philip, 2012, pg. 208)

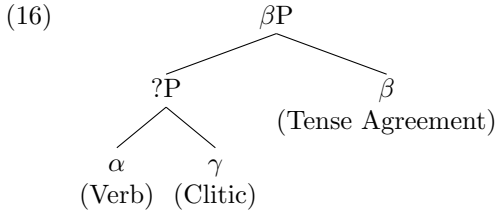
By contrast, Myler (2009) and Roberts (2017) tentatively conclude that FOFC should hold in morphology, particularly in the domain of inflection. (14) would be explained as occurring in separate parts of the deviation. In this way, FOFC involving clitics could help investigate the structure of morphology, although I leave this aside.

There is otherwise the possibility that FOFC is active in some domains, plausibly syntax, but can be overwritten by other constraints, leading to surface violations. This has been seen in the prosodic and phonological analyses of mesoclis (Barbosa, 1996; Harris and Halle, 2005). Similar arguments have been made in the FOFC literature, often in an Optimality-Theoretic approach, allowing locally marked structures to be globally preferred under the right circumstances (DelBusso, 2020; Liao, 2017).

The phonology-syntax interface is particularly important. FOFC has received explanations as a ‘deep’ syntactic constraint (eg. Biberauer et al., 2014), and as a surface Phonological Form (PF) constraint (eg. Duguine, 2022). The outputs which form the acquisition data necessarily do not contain all syntactic data. For this reason, surface violations require particular scrutiny for PF approaches. Duguine argues that FOFC is a PF effect from Basque embedded clause. One minimal pair is given for this.

- (15) a. *Mirenek ez du [Ana etorri d-en] galdetu.*
 Miren NEG AUX Ana come AUX-C ask
 ‘Miren didn’t ask whether Ana came.’
 (Duguine, 2022, (31b))
- b. ?? *Mirenek ez du [ea Ana etorri d-en] galdetu.*
 Miren NEG AUX Q Ana come AUX-C ask
 ‘Miren didn’t ask whether Ana came.’
 (Duguine, 2022, (32a))

The overt addition of a head-initial question marker in (15b) in the clause embedded under a head-final verb degrades it compared to the non-overt equivalent. Duguine concludes that PF strategies act as a last resort to avoid surface FOFC violations - the opposite of suggestions that mesoclis is a last resort strategy creating a FOFC violation to repair other constraints. Related to this matter of phonological output is whether various mesoclis examples constitute a structural FOFC violation. If the clitics are assumed to be base generated with the verb, rather than moved from below, then a Final-over-Initial structure might never be derived. In (16), I leave the labels arbitrary as final position of the tree is in a high location. If γ is the head of $?P$, as expected for affixal or base generated approaches, there is no structural FOFC violation. If α is the head, as expected for at least non-pronominal VO constituents, there is a violation.



The base position of Romance clitics is outside the scope of this paper, although a major topic in Romance linguistics, and there is likely variation between clitics and varieties (Barbosa, 1996). However, for PF approaches to FOFC, the importance of this is reduced, as regardless of the assumed underlying structure, the linear order *verb - object - tense* is FOFC-violating in the wider system of Romance languages as SVO. This is also relevant for approaches to FOFC which highlight the role of processing (Hawkins, 2013; Sheehan, 2017).

3.3 Information Structure

The mesoclis examples occur with movement towards the left periphery, although the location, order and number of movements may differ. The left-periphery has not been seen as relevant to FOFC, as examples of surface violations with topic⁸ fronting can readily be found in English, such as (17).

⁸Surface violations plausibly related to focus fronting can be seen in Finnish (Holmberg, 2017) and Chechen (Komen, 2008) data.

(17) ‘I asked him to help me, and **help me he did.**’

The prosodic marking, and clearly derived nature of such examples mean that they are different to what is expected in unmarked orders. Surface violations can occur more systematically in VO languages with an auxiliary element obligatory in second position, as in the Cornish example (18), where the inflected verb *wrug* requires the preceding particle *a* and a fronted constituent⁹. There are parallels with the Romanian data, although the inflected verb is not a clitic in Cornish.

(18) *Kelli ow hi byghan a wrug vy.*
Lose-INF my dog little PTCL do-1SG-PAST I

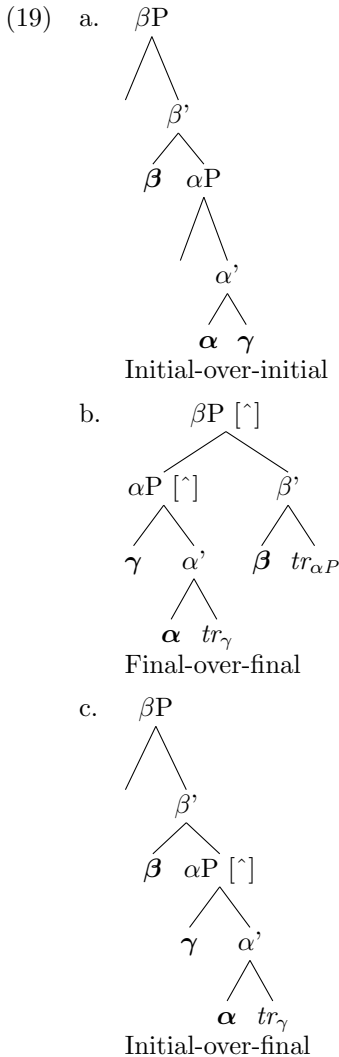
Akademi

‘I lost my little dog.’

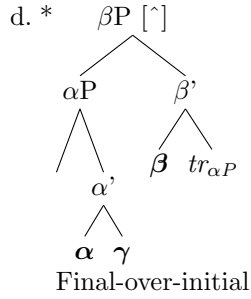
Kernewek (2024), cited in Biberauer and Rowe (shed).

The prosodic marking in the Cornish example is greater than mesoclis, which is seen in the restriction to clitics in the latter.

However, movement is not expected to automatically nullify FOFC restrictions. One of the leading, although far from the only, analyses of FOFC (Biberauer et al., 2014) assumes Kayne (1994)’s Linear Correspondence Axiom (LCA), under which all complement-head linear orders are derived from movement of an underlying VO structure.



⁹ *a* is diachronically a relative particle, but is synchronically the default sentential construction for Middle Cornish (Padel, 2021).



In (19), $[\hat{\cdot}]$ is a feature representing that the verb’s complement moves to its specifier. This feature must apply to a contiguous segment of heads in a given domain, starting from the bottom. This clearly cannot model independent movements to the left periphery. However, we do want FOFC to be able to apply to the C domain, as in (15b) and other evidence (Biberauer et al., 2017).

We can account for this by appealing to granularity and timing of acquisition. FOFC has most significantly been observed in the major categories of the verbal and nominal domains. In certain languages of West Africa, FOFC operates across these domains.

(20) Buli (Niger-Congo) (Cited in Hein and Murphy, 2022, pg. 341 (11))

- a. *d̥ɛ́ mǎngò-kú-lá*
 ate mango-DEM-DEF
 ‘ate that mango’
 (Hiraiwa (2005a)).
- b. *mǎngò-kú d̥ɛ́-kā*
 mango-DEM eat-NMLZ
 ‘eating the mango’
 (Hiraiwa (2005b)).

In (20), basic VO order obligatorily changes to OV when dominated by a head-final nominaliser. The division into objects and predicates (roughly O and V respectively) and their default ordering is acquired very early (Wexler, 1998; Tsimpli, 2014), so the explanation for FOFC should be available at this stage too. Under the Maximise Minimal Means (MMM) approach to language acquisition, these early properties should be acquired from third-factor principles (Chomsky, 2005) from uniform initial conditions (in the form of a minimal Universal Grammar) (Biberauer, 2019; Bosch, 2022). If FOFC is reducible to third-factor considerations (Walkden, 2009), it should aid in bootstrapping early acquisition. Recent findings in MMM show that an undifferentiated C head is available early, long before this splits into Cartographic style projections of finer granularity (Bosch, 2023a,b; Bosch and Biberauer, 2024). This could explain how C heads can participate in FOFC-respecting sequences, whereas IS related movement is acquired later.

On the other hand, FOFC is argued to hold at higher granularity categories (eg. Duguine, 2022, for the full clausal domain in Basque). Part of these differences in granularity might relate to the Duality of Semantics (Chomsky et al., 2023), in whether categories are Internally or Externally merged to a given position at finer granularities in the derivation.

3.4 Prosody

Following on from the discussion on IS, I have already shown how mesoclitisis can give insights into the syntax-prosody interface. It is notable that phonologically small elements like clitics are predicted to be more likely to display disharmonic word orders by Hawkins (2013) due to placing a lower cognitive load for parsing than larger elements. Prosody has also been suggested as relevant to FOFC (Tokizaki, 2014; Branau, 2019)¹⁰, and I shall develop an analysis of this here within MMM. This analysis does not rely on mesoclititic data due to their moved position. The very early word-order phenomena as described above are acquired when there are few footholds into the syntactic system. At this stage, a child is highly sensitive to prosodic factors, and prosodic bootstrapping provides a way into syntax and the lexicon (Guasti, 2016; Soderstrom et al., 2003). For MMM, the asymmetry between VO and OV as a basic order should be deriveable from intonation (Biberauer, 2022). One argument for this is that *weak-strong* rhythmic patterns suggest head-initiality, and *strong-weak* suggest head-finality. Another is that the juncture between complement and head is shorter in head-final structures than in head-initial ones, evidenced by certain phonological rules (Tokizaki,

¹⁰Branau’s analysis is on a general restriction against certain prosodic structures, and is intended as an alternative to FOFC.

2008; Tokizaki and Kuwana, 2013). One example is (21), Japanese Sequential Voicing (*Rendaku*), which occurs between constituents in left- but not right-branching structures.

- (21) a. [[nise tanuki] shiru] → nise **danuki** jiru
 ‘mock-badger soup.’
 b. [nise [tanuki shiru]] → nise tanuki **jiru** (*danuki)
 ‘mock badger-soup.’

FOFC applies across embedded levels of branching structures, and the junctures between constituents following this assumption are given below for the four possibilities. I use bold brackets to indicate a long juncture between constituents.

- (22) a. [T [V [O]]] (Initial-over-Initial)
 b. [[[O] V] T] (Final-over-Final)
 c. [T [[O] V]] (Initial-over-Final)
 d. *[[V [O]] T] (Final-over-Initial)

(22a) and (22b) show again that structurally adjacent heads may have either a short or long juncture. In (22c), there is a long juncture between the structurally non-adjacent T and O, whereas the adjacent O and V have a short juncture. In the FOFC-violating (22d), the structurally adjacent V and O have a long juncture, whereas O and T have only short junctures, which means a reversal of syntactic and prosodic representations. If prosodic bootstrapping is used for early categorial acquisition and the juncture data is true, then the unnaturalness of FOFC-violations falls out easily.

4 Conclusion

In this paper, I have reviewed some common points of discussion in the literature on mesoclis and Analytic Futures in Romance varieties, noting that these phenomena are recurrent across time and space, but display unstable and marked behaviour. The diversity in these phenomena leads to a large number of possible analyses. I have focussed on the linear strings of these examples, which display FOFC-violating orders, which are rare in Romance and crosslinguistically. These structures have not received significant attention in the FOFC literature due to their marked nature, and they are compatible with many explanations for FOFC, limiting their theoretical usefulness in this domain. However, I have shown that these structures may have explanatory power in limiting the scope of FOFC, and highlighting the role of Information Structure and prosody in relation to word-order universals. I have mapped out a more specific proposal for how mesoclis examples should differ from basic early acquired structures under the Maximise Minimal Means approach.

5 Abbreviations

AF Analytic Future
 EP European Portuguese
 FC Future/Conditional
 FOFC Final-over-Final Condition
 IMPF Imperfect
 INF Infinitive
 IS Information Structure
 LCA Linear Correspondence Axiom
 MMM Maximise Minimal Means
 MS Medieval Spanish
 PP Past Participle
 PTCL Particle
 PF Phonological Form
 REFL Reflexive (Particle)
 sCl Subject Clitic
 SF Synthetic Future

6 Sources

CB 1559-1660 Alexandru Gaton (ed.) (2003). *Codicele popii Bratul*. Iași: Editura Universității ‘Alexandru Ioan Cuza’. <http://media.lit.uaic.ro/gafton>.

References

- Akademi Kernewek (2024). Korpus Kernewek. [Cornish Corpus]. Accessed 1st September 2024.
- Alvar, M. and Pottier, B. (1983). *Morfología Histórica del Español*. Gredos.
- Anipa, K. (2000). A Study of the Analytic Future/Conditional in Golden-Age Spanish. *Bulletin of Hispanic Studies*, 77(3):325–338.
- Asztalos, E. (2019). Word Order Change and Disharmony: the Case of Udmurt. Presented at *13th Conference of the Association for Linguistic Typology*. Pavia, 4 September 2019.
- Bach, X. (2024). Mesoclisism in Old Occitan. *Linguistica Pragmensia*, 34(1):7–24.
- Barbosa, P. (1996). Clitic Placement in European Portuguese and the Position of Subjects. In Halpern, A. and Zwicky, A., editors, *Approaching Second: Second Position Clitics and Related Phenomena*, pages 1–40. CSLI Publications.
- Batllori, M. (2011). Mesoclisism and Participle Preposing in Old Spanish and Old Catalan. In *The 13th Diachronic Generative Syntax Conference*.
- Batllori Dillet, M. (2012). Evidentiality in Old Spanish and Old Catalan: Mesoclititic Configurations. In *The 2nd Cambridge Colloquium on the ‘Histories of the Ibero-Romance Languages - Norman MacColl Symposium 2012*.
- Batllori Dillet, M. (2016). El Valor Modal de Haber en los Futuros y Condicionales Analíticos. In *En Torno a ‘Haber’: Construcciones, usos y variación desde el latín hasta la actualidad*, pages 33–78. Peter Lang International Academic Publishers.
- Bernal, J. M. (2004). La Morfología de los Futuros Románicos. Las Formas con Metátesis. *Revista de Filología Románica*, 21:121–169.
- Biberauer, T. (2018). Beyond Word Order – and Syntax: what we can learn from FOFC. Presented at ‘*Current Issues in Comparative Syntax*’. National University of Singapore, 1st March 2018.
- Biberauer, T. (2019). Factors 2 and 3: Towards a Principled Approach. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics*, Special Issue:45–88.
- Biberauer, T. (2022). The Recycling Imperative: an MMM Perspective on the Nature and Origin of Grammatical Features. Talk at Leiden University.
- Biberauer, T., Holmberg, A., and Roberts, I. (2014). A Syntactic Universal and Its Consequences. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 45(2):169–225.
- Biberauer, T., Holmberg, A., Roberts, I., and Sheehan, M. (2017). *Empirical Evidence for the Final-over-Final-Condition*, pages 11–26. The MIT Press.
- Biberauer, T. and Rowe, J. (Unpublished). FOFC in 2024.
- Bosch, N. (2022). Emergence, Complexity and Developing Grammars: a reinterpretation from a Dynamical Systems perspective. *Cambridge Occasional Papers in Linguistics*, 14(1):1–33.
- Bosch, N. (2023a). Emergent Syntax and Maturation: a neo-emergentist approach to syntactic development. Master’s thesis, University of Cambridge.
- Bosch, N. (2023b). Not All Complementisers Are Late: a First Look at the Acquisition of Illocutionary Complementisers in Catalan and Spanish. *Cambridge Occasional Papers in Linguistics*.
- Bosch, N. and Biberauer, T. (2024). Emergent Syntactic Categories and Increasing Granularity: Evidence from a Multilingual Corpus Study. In *Proceedings of the 48th Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD)*.

- Branan, K. (2019). The Left Edge Ban: a Prosodic Requirement Governing Stress Patterns and Word Order. Accessed from <https://sites.google.com/view/kbranan/home>.
- Cardinaletti, A. and Shlonsky, U. (2004). Clitic Positions and Restructuring in Italian. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 35(4):519–557.
- Chomsky, N. (2005). Three Factors in Language Design. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 36(1):1–22.
- Chomsky, N., Seely, T. D., Berwick, R. C., Fong, S., Huybregts, M. A. C., Kitahara, H., McInnerney, A., and Sugimoto, Y. (2023). *Merge and the Strong Minimalist Thesis*. Elements in Generative Syntax. Cambridge University Press.
- Cinque, G. (1999). *Adverbs and Functional Heads: A Cross-Linguistic Perspective*. Oxford University Press.
- Company Company, C. (1985). Los Futuros en el Español Medieval, sus Orígenes y su Evolución. *Nueva Revista de Filología Hispánica (NRFH)*, 34(1):48–107.
- Crysmann, B. (1997). Cliticization in European Portuguese using Parallel Morpho-syntactic Constraints. In *Proceedings of the LFG97 Conference*, pages 1–14.
- DelBusso, N. (2020). The Final-over-Final Condition, Stringency, and Typological Structure. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 51(4):765–784.
- Duguine, M. (2022). FOFC as a PF Phenomenon: Evidence from Basque Clausal Embedding. *Glossa: a Journal of General Linguistics*, 7(1).
- Enrique-Arias, A. and Bouzouita, M. (2013). La Frecuencia Textual en la Evolución Histórica de los Clíticos Pronominales en Español. *Iberoromania*, 77(1):29–46.
- Erlewine, M. Y. (2023). A Syntactic Universal in a Contact Language; the Story of Singlish already. In Nomoto, H. and McCready, E., editors, *Discourse Particles in Asian Languages Volume II*, pages 91–120. Routledge.
- Graham, L. A. (2018). An Analysis of Morphosyntactic Variation in the Old Spanish Future and Conditional. *Journal of Historical Linguistics*, 8(2):192–229.
- Guasti, M. T. (2016). *Language Acquisition: The Growth of Grammar*. MIT Press.
- Halle, M. and Marantz, A. (1994). Some Key Features of Distributed Morphology. *MIT Working Papers in Linguistics*, 21:275–288.
- Halpern, A. (1995). *On the Placement and Morphology of Clitics*. Center for the Study of Language (CSLI).
- Harris, J. and Halle, M. (2005). Unexpected Plural Inflections in Spanish: Reduplication and Metathesis. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 36(2):195–222.
- Haspelmath, M. (2023). Types of Clitics in the World’s Languages. *Linguistic Typology at the Crossroads*, 3(2):1–59.
- Hawkins, J. (2013). Disharmonic Word Orders from a Processing-Efficiency Perspective. In Biberauer, T. and Sheehan, M., editors, *Theoretical Approaches to Disharmonic Word Orders*, pages 391–406. Oxford University Press.
- Hein, J. and Murphy, A. (2022). VP-Nominalization and the Final-over-Final Condition. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 53(2):337–370.
- Hiraiwa, K. (2005a). *Dimensions of symmetry in syntax: Agreement and clausal architecture*. PhD thesis, MIT.
- Hiraiwa, K. (2005b). Predicate clefts in bùlì: Categories and phases. *Linguistic Analysis*, 32:544–583.
- Holmberg, A. (2000). Scandinavian Stylistic Fronting: How Any Category Can Become an Expletive. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 31(3):445–483.
- Holmberg, A. (2017). *The Final-over-Final Condition in a Mixed-Word-Order Language*, pages 297–322. The MIT Press.
- Kayne, R. (1994). *The Antisymmetry of Syntax*. MIT Press.
- Kayne, R. S. (2010). *Toward a Syntactic Reinterpretation of Harris & Halle (2005)*, pages 145–170. John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Komen, E. (2008). Notes on agreement in chechen. Unpublished Manuscript, Nijmegen, Netherlands.

- Laenzlinger, C. (1998). *Comparative Studies in Word Order Variation: Adverbs, Pronouns, and Clause Structure in Romance and Germanic*. John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Ledgeway, A. (2012). *From Latin to Romance: a configurational approach*, pages 181–283. Oxford University Press.
- Lema, J. and Rivero, M.-L. (1989). Long Head Movement: ECP vs. HMC. In Carter, J., Déchaine, R.-M., Philip, B., and Sherer, T., editors, *North East Linguistics Society 20*, volume 2, pages 333–347. GLSA.
- Lema, J. and Rivero, M.-L. (1991). Types of Verbal Movement in Old Spanish: Modals, Futures, and Perfects. *Probus*, 3(3):237–278.
- Liao, W.-w. R. (2017). Remarks on the Final-over-Final Condition: A View from Chinese Head-Final Structures. *Studies in Chinese Linguistics*, 38(2):93–118.
- Manzini, M. R. and Savoia, L. M. (2011). Mesocclisis in the Imperative: Phonology, Morphology or Syntax? *Lingua*, 121(6):1101–1120.
- Manzini, R. and Savoia, L. M. (1999). The Syntax of Middle-reflexive and Object Clitics: a Case of Parametrization in Arberesh Dialects. In Mandalà, M., editor, *Studi in Onore di Luigi Markelaj*, pages 283–328. Adriatica.
- Medeiros, D. P. (2021). A Parsimonious Method for Generating Syntactic Structure.
- Myler, N. (2009). Form, Function, and Explanation at the Syntax/Morphology Interface: Agreement, Agglutination and Post-syntactic Operations. (Extended version). Accessed from <https://sites.google.com/site/neilmylerlinguist/papers>, 21/02/2025.
- Oudin, C. (1597). *Grammaire et Observations de la Langue Espagnolle Recueillies & Mises en François*. Orry.
- Padel, O. J. (2021). English Influence on the Middle Cornish Verbal System. *Zeitschrift für celtische Philologie*, 68(1):255–296.
- Pescarini, D. (2021). *Romance Object Clitics: Microvariation and Linguistic Change*. Oxford University Press.
- Pesetsky, D. (2017). Foreword.
- Philip, J. (2012). (Dis)harmony, the Head-Proximate Filter, and Linkers. *Journal of Linguistics*, 49(1):165–213.
- Primerano, A. and Bouzouita, M. (2024). La Gramaticalización de los Futuros y Condicionales en el Navarroaragonés de los Siglos XIII y XIV: Una Comparación con el Castellano Medieval. *Revue Romane*, 59(1):143–184.
- Rivero, M. L. (1994). Clause Structure and V-movement in the Languages of the Balkans. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*, 12(1):63–120.
- Roberts, I. (2017). *The Final-over-Final Condition in Morphology*, pages 323–346. The MIT Press.
- Savoia, L. M. and Baldi, B. (2023). Enclisis, Mesocclisis and Inflection in Italo-Romance Varieties: A Minimalist Analysis. *Linguistics Beyond and Within (LingBaW)*, 9:172–196.
- Sentí, A. and Bouzouita, M. (2022). The Syntax of Old Catalan Clitics: “Llibre dels Fets”. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics*, 21:47–77.
- Sheehan, M. (2017). *The Final-over-Final Condition and Processing*, pages 79–96. The MIT Press.
- Sheehan, M., Biberauer, T., Roberts, I., and Holmberg, A. (2017). *The Final-Over-Final Condition: A Syntactic Universal*. The MIT Press.
- Silva-Villar, L. (1995). Merge and Cliticization in Old Romance Futures/Conditionals. In *Amsterdam Studies in the Theory and History of Linguistic Science. Series IV*. John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Soderstrom, M., Seidl, A., Nelson, D. G. K., and Jusczyk, P. W. (2003). The Prosodic Bootstrapping of Phrases: Evidence from Prelinguistic Infants. *Journal of Memory and Language*, 49(2):249–267.
- Tokizaki, H. (2008). Symmetry and Asymmetry in the Syntax-Phonology interface. *Phonological Studies*, 11:123–130.
- Tokizaki, H. (2014). Prosody and Head Directionality in Chinese. *Bunka-to Gengo*, 81:1–20.
- Tokizaki, H. and Kuwana, Y. (2013). *A Stress-Based Theory of Disharmonic Word Orders**, pages 190–215. Oxford University Press.

- Tsimpli, I. M. (2014). Early, late or very late?: Timing Acquisition and Bilingualism. *Linguistic Approaches to Bilingualism*, 4(3):283–313.
- Vigário, M. (1999). Pronominal Cliticization in European Portuguese : a Postlexical Operation. *Catalan Working Papers in Linguistics*, 7:219–237.
- Walkden, G. (2009). Deriving the Final-over-Final Constraint from Third Factor Considerations. *Cambridge Occasional Papers in Linguistics*, pages 67–72.
- Wexler, K. (1998). Very Early Parameter Setting and the Unique Checking Constraint: A New Explanation of the Optional Infinitive Stage. *Lingua*, 106(1–4):23–79.
- Whitman, J. (2008). *The Classification of Constituent Order Generalizations and Diachronic Explanation*, pages 233–252. Oxford University Press.
- Whitman, J. and Ono, Y. (2017). Diachronic Interpretations of Word Order Parameter Cohesion. In Mathieu, É. and Trusswell, R., editors, *Micro-change and Macro-change in Diachronic Syntax*, pages 43–60. Oxford University Press.
- Zafiu, R. (2014). Auxiliary Encliticization in 16th Century Romanian: restrictions and regularities. *Linguistica Atlantica*, 33:71–86.
- Zwicky, A. M. (1987). Suppressing the Zs. *Journal of Linguistics*, 23(1):133–148.